Relative to works on other aspects of South Asian history and politics, India's relations with and approach towards Afghanistan have largely evaded scholarly attention. This gap in the literature is surprising not simply because of the strategic relevance of India-Afghanistan relations, but also because of the contradictory narratives it elicits. For some observers, India's role in Afghanistan is marked by intense strategic lethargy, policy incoherence, and indecision.[9] Despite having invested nearly US$2.3 billion in aid and development after 9/11, India remains politically marginalised, if not inconsequential, in Kabul.[10] Pakistan, on the other hand, despite its unhealthy interference in domestic Afghan affairs, has nearly convinced the world of its indispensability for bringing peace in that country. To other observers however, India is waging a well-calibrated, low-level proxy war against Pakistan through Afghanistan. Allegedly, Indian intelligence agencies run training camps for militant Baloch separatists on Afghan soil in order to foment insurgencies in Pakistan.[11] Given the deep historical antipathy between Kabul and Islamabad, India's presence in Afghanistan typifies the quintessential case of the Machiavellian perfidy.[12] Archetypical of 'my enemy's enemy is my friend,' not just India's four consulates (in Jalalabad, Kandahar, Mazar-e-Sharif, and Herat) but also its humanitarian aid and developmental assistance to Afghanistan is viewed with suspicion by Pakistan.[13]

Those who subscribe to the latter view are convinced that hostility between India and Pakistan lies at the heart of the current war in Afghanistan.[14] After all, the friendships that India cultivated in Afghanistan are indicative of its anti-Pakistan bias. For starters, India's political, moral, and military support to the erstwhile anti-Taliban and anti-Pakistan United Front during the 1990s is an open secret. Yet, it is also true that India scaled back its military support to anti-Pakistan elements in Afghanistan after 9/11. In fact, for the most part, modern South Asian history is replete with instances when India refused to engage with Afghanistan (even when asked by its friends in Kabul) in a manner that would undermine, or be seen to be undermining, Pakistan's security, sovereignty, and territorial integrity. For instance, despite the animosity, India maintains a studious silence on Pakistan's claims over the legitimacy of the Durand Line, and has not given in on Afghan desires for diplomatic support on the border dispute.